



How To Book A Tour

Before attempting booking a tour, please consult Chapter 3: Agents, and Chapter 5: Talent Buyers, in “The Music Business for Artist Managers & Self-Management Artists”

Mostly likely, you’ll want to go on tour to support the release of a new album, or even to support a single that’s getting a lot of traction. Touring is just as important as making the album if you want to reach your fans and make money. The goals of your tour other than making money (and as a beginner you’re most likely going to lose money), are to become better known, reach more fans, sell more albums, build your performance skills, and further your career in general. Not to mention... managers, agents and labels don’t want to work with artists who won’t tour.

Generally, the manager is *in charge* of the tour. The agent, in conjunction with the manager, books the tour. When you don’t have an agent, the manager will book the tour. And when you don’t have a manager, a band mate should book the tour. Even if you do have a manager and/or and agent, you can still take part in the booking process.

You might not necessarily be ready to tour, but there are lots of other ways to perform regularly, locally, and make some bucks, including the following:

1) Play Locally

They always say start local and work your way outward, geographically. Having a residency in your hometown, playing once a month at the same venue for a select time frame, will help you gain local fans. Plus, you’ll have a confirmed amount of money coming in each month.

3) Corporate Events

If you’re newer to the game, responding to “cover band” or “party band” advertisements or seeking out these types of gigs can be quite lucrative. These terms are also very heavily searched in Google too. Search for websites that list these types of opportunities and bands, because if you’re looking for quick and easy income, this could be a great start. Build relationships with bar and restaurant managers, event planners at large corporations who hire bands for special events, or special event booking agents.

4) Showcasing

Get connected with your local music associations and find out how to showcase at their industry events. You can get started with a list we have at SmartistU.com/resources.



Booking the Tour

Step 1: Search for Talent Buyers

Use the Contact Directory that comes with the Artist Management Toolkit (see last page of book) and fill it with names, venues/promoters names, locations, emails, links to the contact forms from the website if no emails are given, and a list of ideal dates that you'd like to be in each location. If you don't have their names right off the bat, be sure to add them into the document when they respond to your email. It's important to remember people's names in order to build a relationship with them. Don't re-invent the wheel. I'm sure you're aware of other **artists that can relate to your sound**, check out where they've toured/performed recently to get an idea of which venues would work for your sound and add those venues into your sheet.

Step 2: Find Out Where Your Fans Are

Analytics baby! Check your Facebook, Spotify, email lists and Google analytics for WHERE your current fans are located and try to get shows in those areas.

Step 3: Draft a Routing

The routing (which cities and in which order) will all depend on the availability of the venues, so the sooner in advance you book the better chances you have of getting what you want, but you'll still want to draft a routing before contacting the venues and promoters. If they don't have the date you want, ask for any surrounding dates that are available, and re-route as you get offers. As the talent buyers suggested in chapter 5, book your shows anywhere from 2-6 months in advance for a 50-500 seat venue. For 500+ book 6-12 months in advance.

- It will help your cause if you check the venues website first to see if they already have someone booked on the night you want your show.
- Make sure you check Google Maps to find out how long it'll take to get from place to place, with time changes, and plan for that accordingly.
- Save money: try to make the most efficient routing as possible and avoid driving back and forth over and over again. This is sometimes hard to avoid but if you can then you will save time and money on gas.
- Copy another bands routing. Again, no need to reinvent the wheel.
- The more shows you book during the week the more likely you are to break-even or come out with some positive cash flow, but you also need to include breaks for both vocals and driving time. If you can, try to book about 5 shows a week.

Step 4: Write Your Email



Refer the Show Booking Email Template included in this Touring Kit.

Step 5: Advance the Show

Advances and Riders: You'll need to advance the show, in advance of the show, get it? Some venues have standard documents that include all of the information you need, some will happily give it to you over the phone, some wonder why you're even asking. The main information you need to find out is if they offer accommodations or if they can find you discounts, when load-in and sound-check is, your set times, parking information, if they offer complimentary food and drink or give you extra cash instead (called a buyout), how many people you can have on guest list, and if they can pay you cash at the end of the night. You can also ask for stage plots and tech info if you so need.

*A Booking Advance Sheet is conveniently included with the Artist Management Toolkit.

What If I'm A Totally New Band or New to That Market?

Let's say you have zero stats, little noteworthy items, and can't prove any audience or pay-off for the venue to book you. Then you simply send them a link to your best possible song, stating what you're up to in a professional manner, and that you'd like to play at their venue to build your audience. The music will dictate whether or not they add you to someone else's bill.

If you're just new to that market and don't have stats, but have played shows before, simply say:

"We played __ venue recently, we had __ fans show up, and we sold \$__ in CD's and T-shirts".

Don't undersell, don't oversell. Just be real.

What NOT to Do

1. Get the person's name wrong
2. Get the venue name wrong
3. EXTRA WARNING: Since you'll be sending essentially the same email to all venues/promoters, you'll be doing a lot of copy and pasting and forwarding, so MAKE SURE you change the email subject, and the names of venues and dates within the email. You'll look partially (or fully) stupid if you don't.